

Blue Tigresses rise again

Four years after a heartbreaking withdrawal, the Indian women's football team returns to the Asian Cup with renewed belief and a **World Cup spot** within reach.

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Life often pivots on the unforeseen. For a football team preparing for a tournament, injuries or sudden health scares can quickly derail months of planning and ambition. But it is also about second chances. Ask the national women's football team, which qualified for the Asian Cup on merit for the first time this year.

Back in 2022, when it qualified as host, it was supposed to be its first appearance after nearly two decades. But when COVID-19 crept into the camp, the team had no option but to withdraw.

In the months that followed, its FIFA ranking dropped, Olympic qualification dreams faded, and aspirations fizzled out into complete darkness, the side drifting into obscurity.

Now, with the men's team out of the Asian Cup qualification race, the only roar audible is that of the Blue Tigresses.

"It doesn't matter what happens, the team will try to make this tournament mark a new beginning for women's football in India," Amelia Valverde, India's coach, tells *Sportstar*.

India bulldozed Iraq, Mongolia and Timor-Leste before stunning Thailand — the 1983 Asian Cup champion and last edition's quarterfinalist — to make it to this edition, set

Tough road: India will be pitted against heavyweights Japan, Vietnam and Chinese Taipei — all higher-ranked sides, with the first two having played in the previous FIFA Women's World Cup. **AIFF MEDIA**

